

PLAYBOOK

Plays from the work.

Practical notes and working tools on building a business that can keep moving. Written from the store floor, the development schedule, the site walk, and the franchise pipeline.

**THE STRONGEST
PERFORMER BECOMES
THE BIGGEST SINGLE
POINT OF FAILURE.**

Why Your Best Manager Cannot Be the Whole System

Make the knowledge useful beyond one person.

TAVIS SCHOLZ · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026 · 2 MIN READ

You know the store. It runs tight when your best GM is on the floor and gets shaky the moment she's not. Vacation week, a family emergency, or just Saturday afternoon— the second she's out of the business, the numbers wobble, newer hires start underperforming and making calls that don't match what "good" looks like, and you're fielding questions that should never have reached you.

The instinct is to read this as a personnel problem: find another manager like her, pay to keep her, hope nothing happens to her. That's the wrong diagnosis. The real problem is that everything the store runs on lives in one person's head instead of in the store's system. She's not just managing the location, she is the training program, the standards, the judgment calls on staffing gaps and vendor relationships. None of that has a home outside of her. That's not loyalty or talent, that's exposure.

"The strongest performer becomes the biggest single point of failure."

I've seen this play out the same way across different brands and different store sizes: the strongest performer becomes the biggest single point of failure, and nobody notices until the day she's gone. The fix isn't a 40-page operations manual nobody reads. It's capturing the handful of judgment calls that actually separate her store from an average one, the stuff that never made it into training because it felt obvious to her.

Here's the practical move. Don't ask your best manager to write anything down. She won't prioritize it, and even if she tries, she'll write what she thinks she's supposed to say, not what she actually does. Instead, sit with her for 45 minutes and walk through two things: her opening routine, step by step, and one real problem she solved in the last two weeks without calling anyone. Write down the decisions in that conversation where a newer manager would have gotten it wrong. That list, not a manual, is your starting system. It's usually five to eight items, and it's almost never what corporate training already covers.

THIS WEEK

Book 45 minutes with your best manager. Ask her to talk you through her opening routine and the last problem she solved on her own. Write down every decision point where a less experienced manager would've guessed wrong. That's the first page of a system that survives her.

5 Things Your Opening Checklist Must Cover

The dates and handoffs that should never surprise the team.

TAVIS SCHOLZ · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026 · 3 MIN READ

The final inspection for the occupancy permit gets pushed two and a half weeks out. Nobody dropped the ball on purpose. The fire marshal came through on the first pass, found a handful of corrective items before he'd sign off (a couple of exit signs, a sprinkler head clearance issue, an alarm zone that didn't test clean) and had to schedule a return visit. That part is routine. What isn't routine is that four days passed before anyone outside construction knew about it, because nobody was treating a held inspection as urgent information that had to move immediately.

That's not really a fire marshal problem, and it's not really a construction problem either. It's a communication gap wearing a scheduling problem's clothes. A failed or held-up inspection is information, and information sitting in one person's inbox for four days is functionally the same as no information at all. Real estate and ops were still planning around the original inspection date because nobody told them it had slipped, so by the time they adjusted staffing, training, and the marketing spend, they were reacting instead of managing.

“A schedule with no room for either isn't a schedule, it's a hope.”

The fix is still one document, one owner per line, tracked from lease execution through grand opening, plus a rule sitting on top of it: any inspection that doesn't clear clean gets flagged to every downstream owner the same day, not once the punch list is resolved. Not a project plan with 200 tasks nobody looks at again after week one. Just the dates that, if missed, cause real damage: a blown labor plan, a marketing push that launches into an empty store, or a certificate of occupancy that lands later than the lease requires.

A starting template

MILESTONE	OWNER
Lease execution date	Real Estate
Permit submission date	Construction
Utility turn-on request (30+ days out)	Construction
Rough construction milestone (framing/MEP complete)	Construction
Health department pre-inspection walkthrough	Construction, confirmed by Ops
Final health/fire/building inspection scheduled	Construction
Escalation on any failed or held inspection result (same day)	Whoever received the result
POS and back-office systems install date	IT/Ops
Store manager hire date (target: 6-8 weeks pre-open)	Ops/HR
Staff hiring complete	Store Manager
Training start date	Ops
Inventory/first order delivery date	Ops

MILESTONE**OWNER**

Soft open date

Ops

Grand opening / marketing launch date

Marketing

The column that actually prevents surprises isn't the date, it's the named owner, and the rule that a held inspection gets reported the same day is what keeps a routine correction from turning into a two-week slip. Build five to seven days of buffer into your target inspection date. Fire marshals get backed up, punch lists happen, and a schedule with no room for either isn't a schedule, it's a hope.

THIS WEEK

Pull your last three store openings. For each one, check whether the final CO or fire inspection cleared on the first pass. If it didn't, find out how many days passed between the failed result and the moment real estate, ops, or marketing found out about it. That gap, not the fire marshal's calendar, is what actually cost you time.

A Good Site Can Still Be the Wrong Location

Evaluate the market, not just the address.

TAVIS SCHOLZ · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026 · 2 MIN READ

The site checks every box. Traffic count is strong, demographics match the target profile, visibility is good, parking works. Everyone signs off. Eighteen months later, it's underperforming and nobody can point to what the checklist missed, because the checklist didn't miss anything. The address was fine. The market wasn't.

Here's what's actually going on. A standard site scorecard evaluates a location in isolation: this corner, this traffic count, this population within three miles. What it doesn't evaluate is the location relative to everything else already competing for the same customer, including your own other stores. I've watched a genuinely strong address underperform because it sat inside the trade area of an existing location that was already capturing most of the demand in that market. The new store didn't grow the pie, it split it.

"The address was fine. The market wasn't."

The other blind spot cuts the opposite direction. Some of the best-performing stores in a portfolio sit on sites that would've scored average on a textbook checklist, because what actually drove their performance wasn't the address, it was something about the

market itself: a customer base with higher visit frequency, a competitive set that was weaker than it looked on paper, a market where the brand had disproportionate word-of-mouth. A generic site model won't catch that, because it's not scoring the market, it's scoring the corner.

The practical fix is to stop evaluating a new site against a generic checklist and start evaluating it against your own portfolio's actual pattern. Take your best and worst performing stores and lay out what's genuinely different about the markets around them, not the sites. Population density, yes, but also competitive saturation, drive time patterns, and whether the new location would be feeding off an existing store or capturing net-new demand. That's a market model built from your own results, and it will tell you things a national site-selection template never will.

THIS WEEK

List your three best and three worst performing stores. Next to each, write down what's actually different about the market, not the address: competitive density, overlap with your own other locations, drive patterns, customer frequency. If you can't answer that for your current portfolio, you don't have a site model yet, you have a checklist, and those are not the same thing.

How Your Item 19 Will Break Your Sales Pipeline

The gap between what your reps say and what your FDD proves is where deals die.

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A candidate is six weeks into the pipeline and everything's gone right. Discovery Day landed well, the unit economics conversation felt honest, and they're telling you they're ready to sign. Then their attorney finishes the mandatory FDD review, and the deal goes quiet. Not because the numbers in Item 19 were bad. Because they weren't the numbers the candidate had already been told.

Item 19 is the only place in the entire franchise sales process where a financial performance claim is legally allowed to exist. Under the FTC Franchise Rule, any earnings statement made outside it, spoken, emailed, or implied in a slide, by a rep, a broker, or an existing franchisee acting on the franchisor's behalf, is a violation, whether or not anyone meant it that way. Most sales teams don't sit down and decide to break that rule. It happens gradually, over a six- to twelve-week relationship, as a rep fields the same question over and over and starts filling the silence: "our strongest stores tend to run higher," or "that number's a system average, yours would probably do better in a market like this." None of that is in the FDD. All of it is now what the candidate believes going in. When their attorney compares the document to the conversation during the mandatory review window, the gap reads as one of two things: the franchisor oversold, or the number itself can't be trusted. Either read kills momentum at the single most

expensive point to lose a candidate, after months of nurturing, right before the signature.

“Any daylight between the two is exactly where your pipeline is leaking.”

The fix isn't telling your sales team to stop talking about money. Candidates will ask regardless. It's giving them a specific, compliant answer that maps directly to whatever Item 19 actually says this year, so there's nothing left to freelance. If your FDD makes no earnings claim at all, that answer is short and it should be memorized word for word, not improvised under pressure. If it does include a financial performance representation, the sales team needs the plain-English version of exactly what it covers and, just as important, what it deliberately leaves out (which markets, which unit ages, which outliers got excluded), because the deliberate gaps are exactly where reps tend to guess. Review that mapping every time Item 19 changes, not once when it's written.

THIS WEEK

Pull the last five to ten deals that stalled or died after the FDD went out. For each one, find out specifically what came up, whether the number itself was the problem, or it didn't match something the candidate had already heard. Those are two different problems, and only one of them is actually about performance. Then ask your sales team, without letting them check the FDD first, what they'd say out loud if a candidate asked about earnings today. Compare that answer to what Item 19 actually permits. Any daylight between the two is exactly where your pipeline is leaking.



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